

WHAT DEFINES A GOOD LEADER?

Inside the leadership gap between Michelle Obama, Donald Trump, and J.D. Vance - through the eyes of UO students.

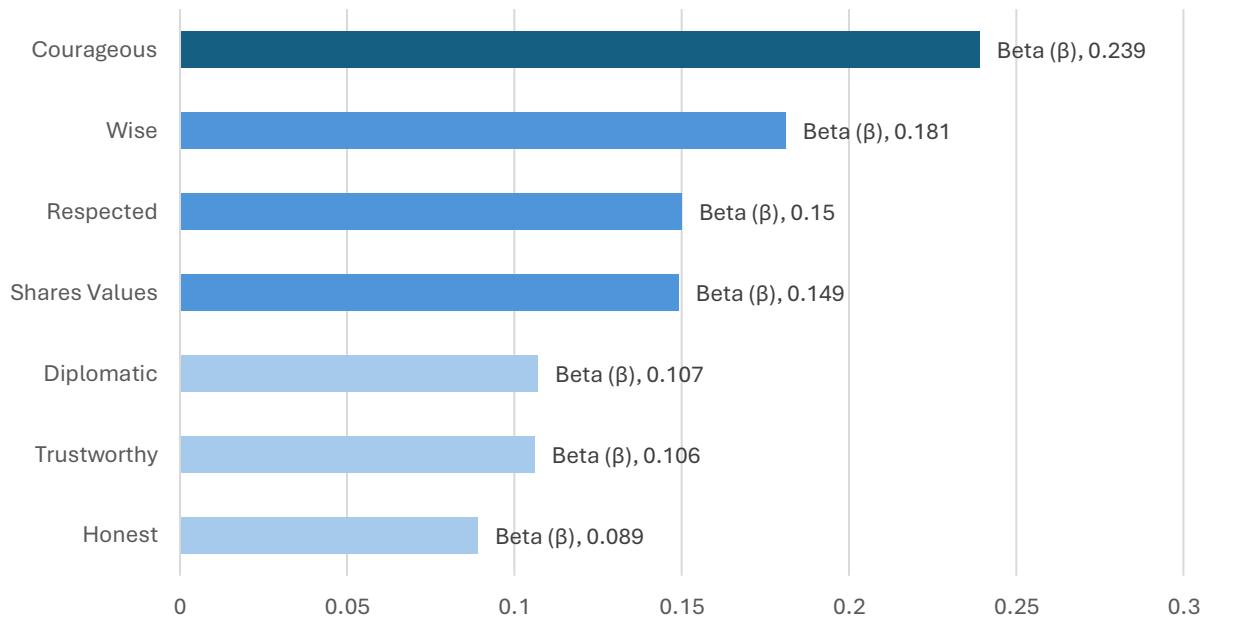
To better understand how University of Oregon students define leadership, I surveyed the campus on five prominent, modern leadership brands — *Michelle Obama, Donald Trump, J.D. Vance, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, and Gavin Newsom* — and examined which traits most strongly influence perceptions of leadership. Participants also reported their political ideology, primary news source, college, and hometown.

ARTICLE ROADMAP
Part 1 → The Leader Standard (*regression: what traits drive “excellent” leadership ratings*)
Part 2 → Three Brand Evaluations (*crosstabs: Obama vs. Trump vs. Vance ratings, by ideology*)
Part 3 → What Shapes the Split (*media environment + college context as amplifiers*)

THE LEADERSHIP CHECKLIST

↳ *Seven traits that reliably push a leader’s “excellent” rating higher.*

To identify what students seek in a leader, I ran a *stepwise regression* using Zelenskyy’s ratings as the dependent variable. Zelenskyy was selected because students evaluated him through a consistent moral lens which made the model clean and interpretable.



Interpreting the Model:

The final model explains **68% of the variation** in his ratings (adjusted $R^2 = .68$, $p < .001$). Seven traits entered the final model, all significant at $p < .001$.

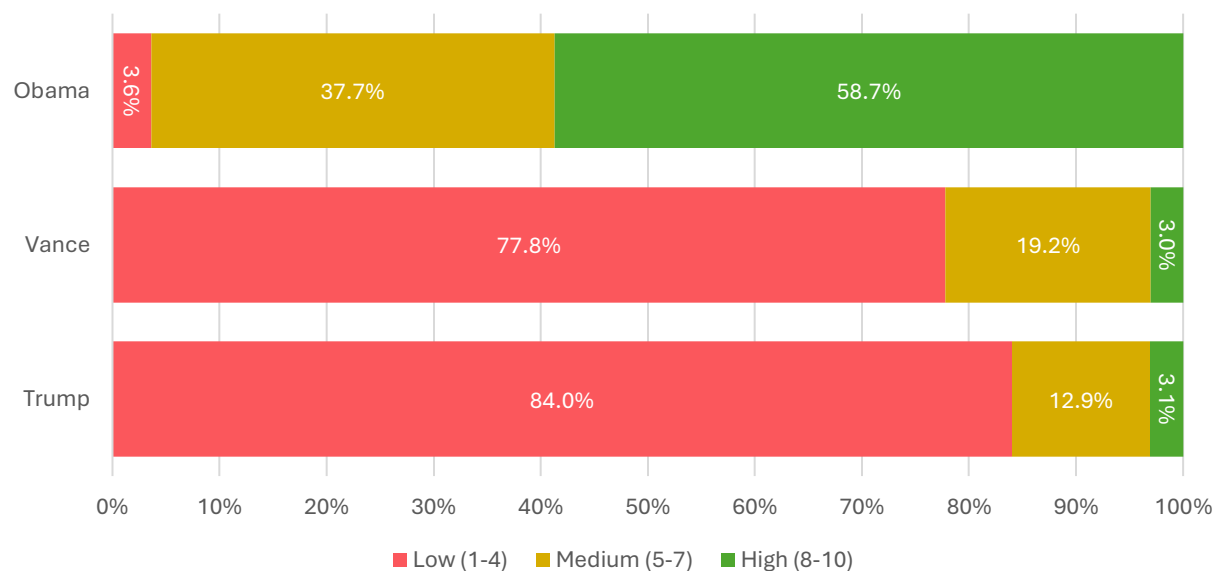
The *standardized Beta* (β) tells us each trait's relative punch: higher β = bigger effect on the rating. The single strongest predictor is *courage* ($\beta = 0.239$). Close behind are *wisdom* ($\beta = 0.181$) and *being respected* ($\beta = 0.150$).

KEY FINDING: Students share a common "leader checklist": courage, wisdom, respect, shared values, diplomacy, trust, and honesty. The disagreement is not about *what* makes a leader excellent, it's about *who* fits that description.

STANDARD AGREEMENT, THREE DIFFERENT VERDICTS

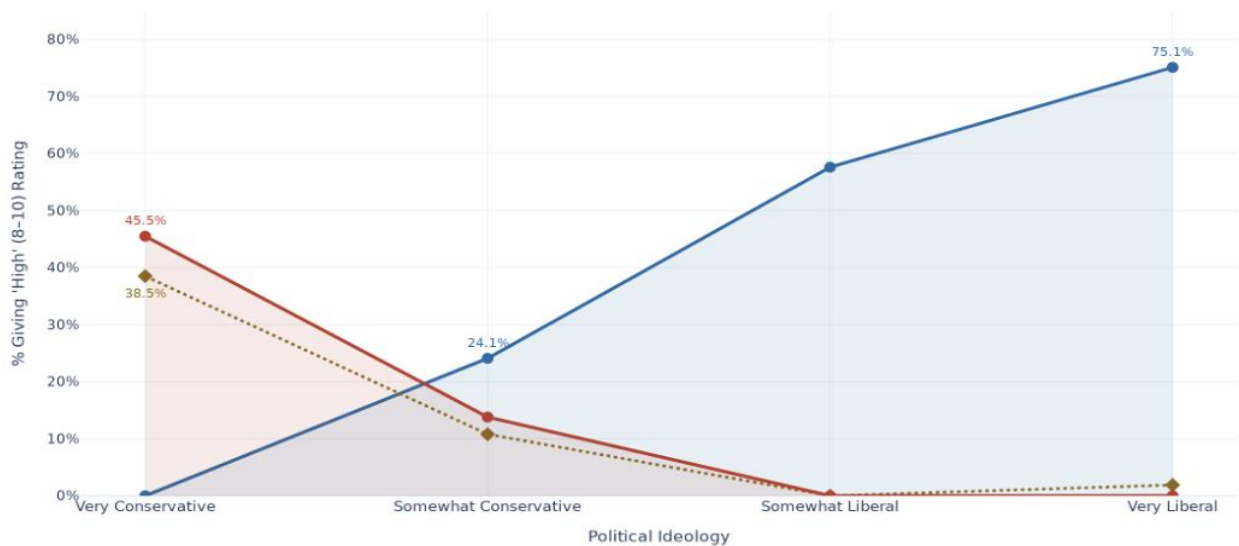
↳ How students rate the Obama, Vance, & Trump brands overall

Here we can observe the results of students applying their shared leader checklist to real people. The Obama brand receives **High (8–10)** ratings from **58.7% of students**, while fewer than 4% give her a Low rating (1-4). Trump and J.D. Vance land almost identically at the bottom: **84.0% give Trump a Low** and only 3.1% rate him High; **77.8% give Vance a Low** and only 3.0% rate him High.



Very liberal students are nearly unanimous: **99.5%** give Trump a Low and **95.7%** give Vance a Low. Obama climbs to 75.1% High among very liberals.

On the other side, very conservative students split meaningfully: Vance earns a High rating from **38.5%** of students and Trump earns **45.5%**, a gap of just 7 percentage points. Among somewhat conservatives, Vance reaches **10.8% High** and Trump reaches **13.8% High**. In ratings from liberals of both types, today's leaders of the U.S. collapse to near-zero.



KEY FINDING: Obama's brand dominates across nearly every ideology group. Trump and Vance form a paired conservative counter-brand. Both scored low by liberals and both elevated (but not dominant) by conservatives. Liberals are *locked in*; conservatives are *internally divided*.

TWO NAMES, ONE BRAND

↳ J.D. Vance tracks Trump across every ideology group, but always scores lower.

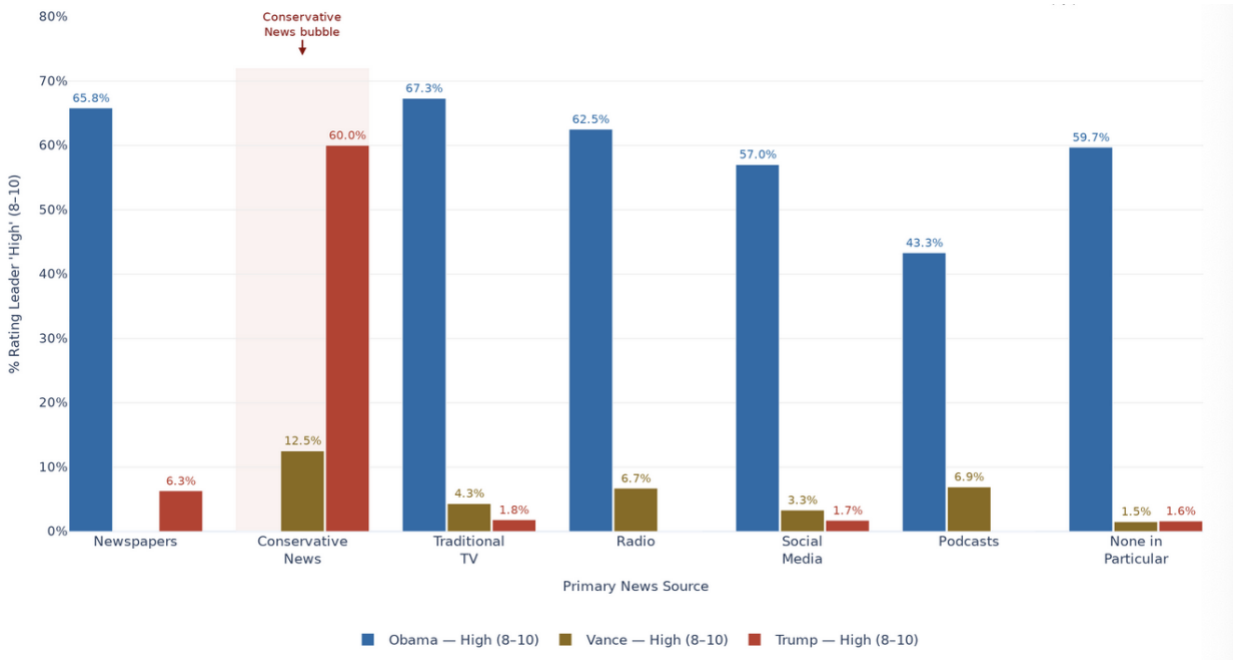
This parallel collapse is the key structural finding: Vance does not hold an *independent brand* among UO students. He is perceived as a weaker version of Trump.

In fact, Trump's own 'Excellent Leader' rating entered the J.D. Vance regression model as a statistically significant predictor ($p < .05$). Meaning students who rate Trump highly are *significantly more likely to rate Vance highly* even after accounting for all of Vance's own character traits. The brand association runs deeper than trait perceptions alone.

KEY FINDING: Obama occupies one pole of the UO leadership space *alone*. The conservative counter-pole is occupied by both Trump and Vance, but Trump is the *primary brand* and Vance is the *brand extension*, with all the signal dilution that implies.

NEWS FEED INFLUENCE

↳ Primary news source predicts which leader brand students elevate & the conservative bubble is narrow but intense.



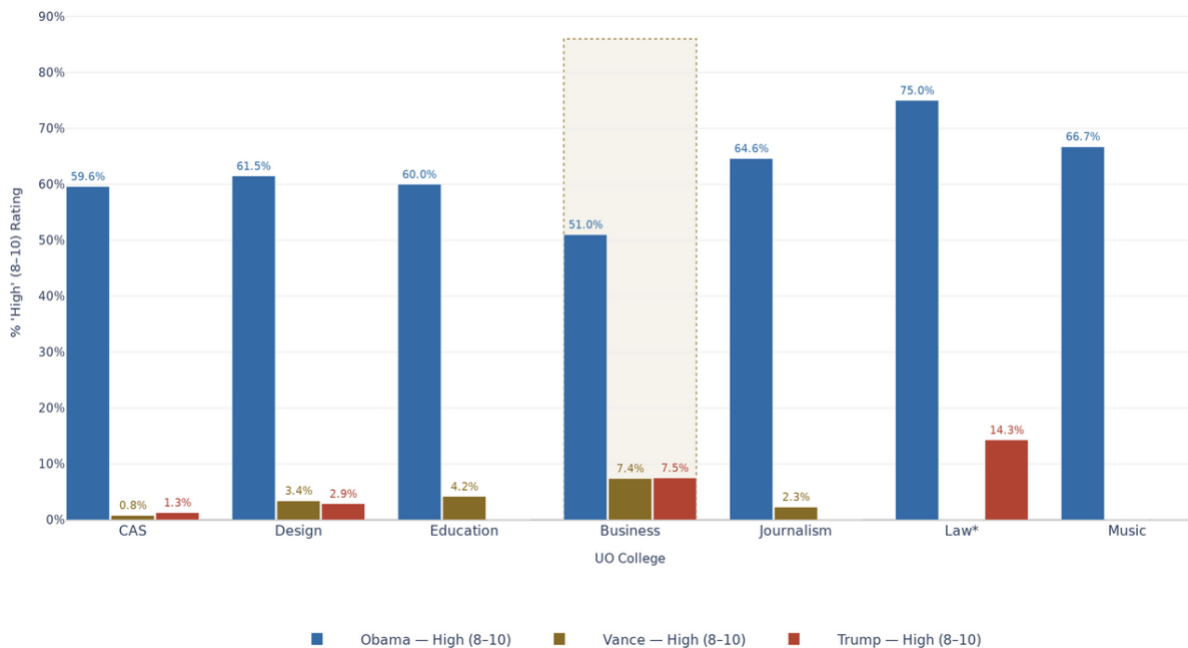
Students named their primary news source, and the results map almost perfectly onto the brand split. Conservative news users stand *entirely apart* from every other group: **60.0% rate Trump High**, **12.5% rate Vance High**, and **0.0% rate Obama High**.

This is the only source group where the conservative brand clears even a moderate 'High' threshold, and it remains the only environment where Trump outperforms Obama.

KEY FINDING: Media environment functions as a brand filter. Conservative news is the only environment where the Trump/Vance counter-brand gains real traction. In every other media world (newspapers, TV, radio, social media, podcasts) Obama's brand dominates and both Trump and Vance hover near 0% of “excellent” leadership ratings.

THE FINAL PICTURE

↳ College context reinforces the brand split. A synthesis diagram shows how all three forces converge.



College affiliation mirrors the media pattern at the campus level. Obama's 'High' rating holds above *50% in every single UO college*. From 51% in Business to 75% in Law. Regardless of major, the majority of UO students in every school rate the Obama brand highly.

Trump's 'High' rating reaches meaningful levels only in **Business (7.5%)** and **Law (14.3%)**. Vance's 'High' peaks identically in **Business (7.4%)**, matching Trump's ceiling almost exactly with a slight uptick in Education (4.2%).

In Arts & Sciences, Journalism, and Music, both Trump and Vance record 0.0–2.3% High ratings. Academic environments centered on public service, critical media, and the arts produce near-unanimous rejection of the conservative brand.

SYNTHESIS: ONE STANDARD, THREE BRAND POSITIONS

UO students hold a *shared leader checklist* of courage, wisdom, respect, shared values, trust, diplomacy, and honesty. The disagreement is entirely about which real people *fit* that checklist.

Obama is cast as the near-universal embodiment of the standard: she holds above 50% 'High' in every college, every news audience except conservative media, and every ideology group except very conservative. **Trump and Vance** form a paired counter-brand that is rejected by liberals nearly unanimously and elevated by conservatives, but even there, never by a majority. Trump leads the conservative brand; Vance borrows credibility from it. Neither breaks through as 'excellent' outside their narrow ideological and media niche.

Ulys Chauncey Drumrongthai

Primary Researcher · Data Analyst · Author

University of Oregon · Spring 2026